

From Event to Infrastructure

*Building career guidance and counselling
at national scale in India*

For policymakers, board and regulatory leaders, school and university heads, industry and CSR funders, and guidance providers

Rebuilt and extended from the ProTeen handbook "Career Counselling in the 21st Century" (2022), with an updated evidence base, an investment case and a decision agenda.

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How to use this handbook

Time-poor readers: read the Executive Summary (page 4) and Chapter 11, the decision agenda by stakeholder.

Programme designers: Chapters 4–9 set out the science, journey, skills, safeguarding, technology and workforce standards.

Practitioners: Appendix A preserves the counsellor reference sheets from the original handbook, updated and caveated.

ABOUT THIS EDITION

Basis of preparation

What was kept, what was replaced, and how to read the numbers.

This edition rebuilds the 2022 ProTeen handbook, *Career Counselling in the 21st Century*, for a different reader. The original was written for counsellors. This version is written for the people who decide whether, how and at what scale India invests in career guidance: education departments, boards and regulators, institution heads, funders and employers, and the providers who serve them.

What was kept. The core architecture of the original is sound and is retained: the “3-Dimensional Awareness” model (know yourself, know the career landscape, know the fit), the iterative Grade 8–college journey, the five-stage counselling process, the emphasis on 21st-century skills, the integration of mental health, and the code of ethics. Practitioner reference sheets are preserved in Appendix A.

What was changed. Four things. First, the evidence base is refreshed to October 2026; much of the original relied on 2015–2021 sources, and the policy landscape has moved materially since (Chapter 1). Second, claims that were unsourced or overstated were corrected or retired (Appendix B lists each). Third, the assessments are graded for evidence strength rather than presented as equally valid (Chapter 4). Fourth, the document adds what a decision-maker needs and the original lacked: supply-gap sizing, a cost model, an operating model, stakeholder decisions, KPIs, risks and a 36-month roadmap.

Vendor neutrality. The original was published by a commercial platform and described its own products throughout. This edition is deliberately provider-agnostic. Where it makes recommendations on technology it does so through procurement criteria (Chapter 8), not product endorsement.

How to read the numbers

- **Official statistics** (PLFS, UDISE+, AISHE, NCRB, NMHS) are cited to the issuing body. Several were accessed through press or analyst summaries of the official release; Appendix D flags each.
- **Modelled figures** (counsellor requirements, costs, tier shares) are this handbook’s own illustrative estimates, with assumptions shown in Appendix C. They are planning aids, not forecasts, and should be treated as $\pm 30\%$.
- **Associational evidence.** International research linking career guidance to better outcomes (Chapter 3) is largely longitudinal and associational. There is, to our knowledge, no Indian causal evaluation at scale. Closing that gap is a built-in milestone of the roadmap.
- **Series breaks.** PLFS was redesigned in January 2025 and UDISE+ adopted NEP stage definitions; figures before and after are not strictly comparable.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Executive summary: the case and the ask

India has decided guidance matters. The unfinished work is making it real for 6.5 crore students.

15.9%

Youth (15–29) unemployment, Apr–Jun 2026, a series high

22.75 lakh

NEET-UG 2026 registrants for 1.30 lakh MBBS seats

14,488

Student suicides recorded in 2024, +80% since 2014

6.48 crore

Students in Classes 9–12 who need guidance

1. The problem is a decision problem, and it is acute. Indian students make irreversible-feeling choices at 15 and 17 with thin information and heavy social pressure. Registrations for a single exam (NEET-UG) exceed the seats it serves by about 18 to 1, and by about 36 to 1 for government seats. Youth unemployment reached 15.9% in April–June 2026, the highest in the revamped PLFS series, and 19.6% for young women. Generative AI is compressing entry-level hiring: in a February 2026 ICRIER survey of 651 IT firms, 55% reported lower junior-level headcount against 35% reporting an increase.

2. The policy window is open, and the mandate is ahead of capacity. Within eighteen months India has gained a Supreme Court direction (July 2025) that every institution with 100 or more students engage a qualified counsellor, a CBSE circular (19 January 2026) mandating both a career counsellor and a socio-emotional counsellor at 1:500 for Classes 9–12, and a data-protection regime for children's data that takes full effect in May 2027. Mandates, however, do not create people, standards or evidence. At CBSE's 1:500 norm India needs roughly 1.3 lakh career counsellors for Classes 9–12 alone, before socio-emotional counsellors and before colleges.

3. The evidence supports acting, with humility about what is proven. OECD analysis of longitudinal datasets across multiple countries finds that teenagers who explore, experience and think about their futures in work tend to see lower unemployment, higher wages and greater career satisfaction as adults. Guidance can partly offset disadvantage. But this evidence is associational, and India has no large causal evaluation. The programme must therefore be built to learn.

4. The right model is tiered, not human-only. A human-only 1:500 model costs an illustrative ₹7,800 crore a year (about ₹1,200 per student). A tiered hybrid model, combining universal digital career education and teacher coordinators with counsellor time reserved for decision points and high-need students, delivers broad coverage at about ₹5,000 crore (about ₹775 per student). A digital-first hub-and-spoke variant for remote areas is about ₹3,300 crore. Cost, not conviction, is the binding constraint, and design choices move it by more than half.

5. Quality is the real risk. The most likely failure is not under-funding but a large cohort of under-trained counsellors administering unvalidated tools to children, producing biased recommendations and mishandling distress. The evidence grading in Chapter 4, the competency tiers in Chapter 9 and the procurement criteria in Chapter 8 exist to prevent it.

Decisions we are asking for (detail in Chapter 11)

- **Union and state governments:** fund a three-state, 300-school pilot of the tiered model with an independent matched-control evaluation; set up a national counsellor competency framework and registry within nine months.
- **Boards and regulators:** adopt a common validation and fairness standard for assessment tools used with minors; recognise the three-tier counsellor structure.
- **Institution heads:** appoint a named career lead and protect timetabled career periods in Grades 8–12 now, without waiting for the counsellor supply to arrive.
- **Funders and employers:** underwrite Tier-3 inclusion (rural, first-generation, at-risk students) and open workplace exposure, mentoring and internships to schools.
- **Providers:** publish validity, norming and bias-audit evidence; accept data-portability and no-profiling terms; price transparently.

PART I | THE CASE FOR ACTION

1. Why now: a decision problem with rising stakes

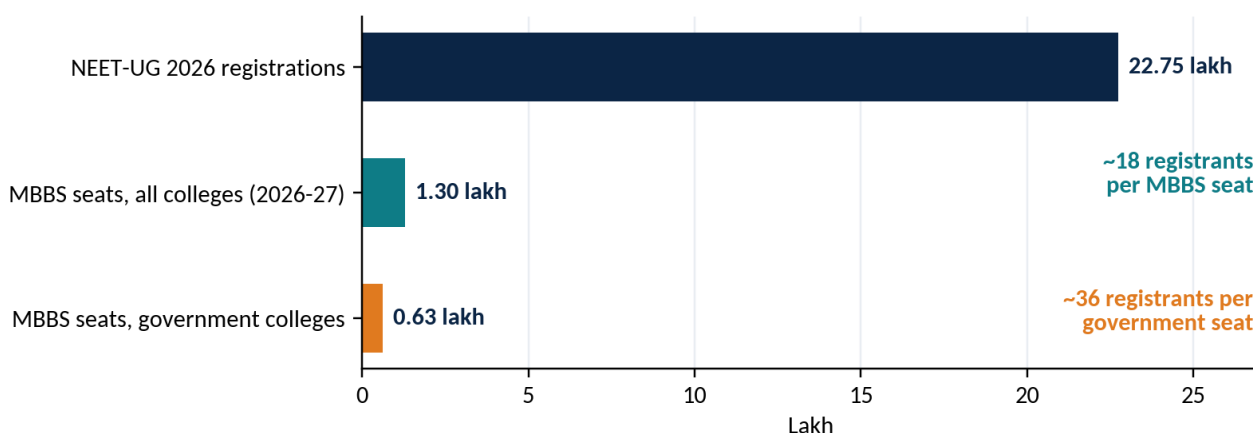
Three pressures have converged: narrow choices made early, a tightening entry-level labour market, and a measurable well-being cost.

1.1 Choices are made early, narrowly and with thin information

Career selection in a typical Indian household begins around Grade 9, at the dinner table, weighing a child's visible marks against a parent's dated view of what has "scope". The result is herding into a few prestige tracks. NEET-UG 2026 drew about 22.75 lakh registrations; the country has roughly 1.30 lakh MBBS seats, of which about 63,000 are in government colleges. Even allowing for repeaters, students who also apply abroad and those who hold other options, upwards of nine in ten registrants will not secure an MBBS seat.

EXHIBIT 1

Registrations outnumber medical seats by about 18 to 1, and government seats by about 36 to 1



Source: NTA (NEET-UG 2026 registrations, 22,75,011); MBBS seat matrix 2026-27 (1,29,603 seats; 63,160 government) as reported by Allen and Collegedunia; ratios calculated by this handbook. Registrations include repeaters.

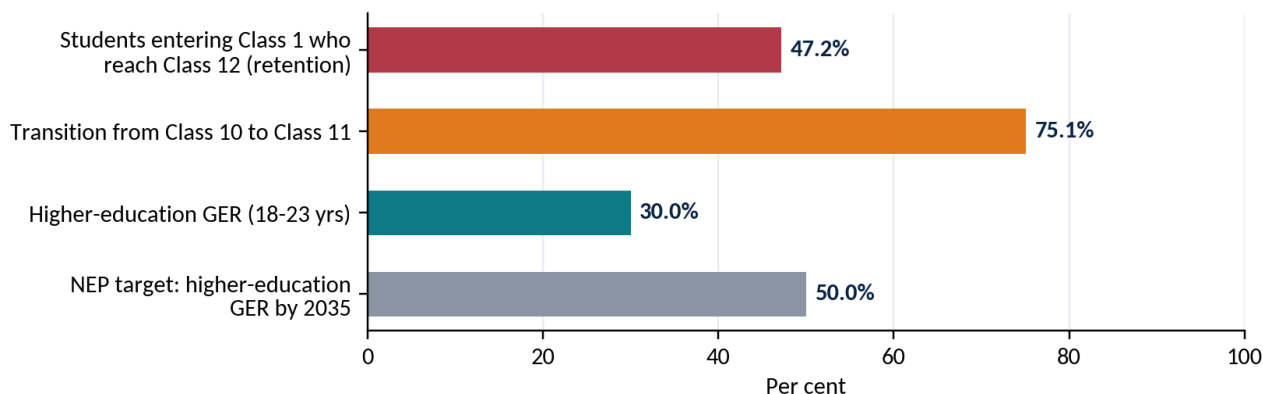
The point is not that medicine or engineering are poor choices. It is that a choice made under social pressure and information scarcity carries a large hidden cost: years of preparation, family expenditure and psychological load, followed by a forced pivot at 19 or 20. Guidance earlier and better informed spreads that choice across a wider, more realistic set of options before the preparation investment is sunk.

1.2 The school pipeline leaks before and after the decisions that matter

Under the NEP 5+3+3+4 structure, Classes 9–12 are the secondary stage, enrolling about 6.5 crore students (UDISE+ 2024-25). Retention to Class 12 is only 47.2% of an entering Class 1 cohort, and 75.1% of students transition from Class 10 to Class 11. Higher-education GER reached 30.0% in 2023-24 (AISHE), against the NEP goal of 50% by 2035. Each of these hand-offs is a decision point where well-timed guidance can change a trajectory, particularly for first-generation learners who have no family template to follow.

EXHIBIT 2**Fewer than half of students entering school reach Class 12, and higher-education participation is 30%**

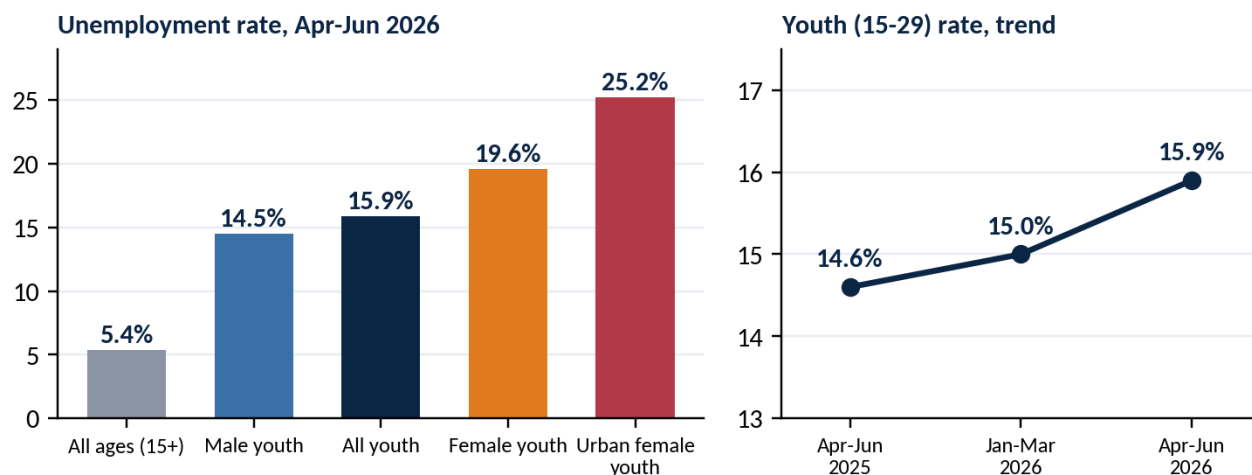
Selected pipeline indicators, per cent



Source: UDISE+ 2024-25 (Ministry of Education); AISHE 2023-24 (released July 2026); NEP 2020 target. Retention and transition indicators use NEP stage definitions; see Appendix D on comparability.

1.3 The labour market students enter is tightening, especially for freshers

The Periodic Labour Force Survey (revamped from January 2025) reports an overall unemployment rate of 5.4% for April–June 2026, but 15.9% for ages 15–29, up from 14.6% a year earlier. Young women fare worst: 19.6% overall and 25.2% in urban areas. A headline rate near 5% therefore conceals a youth problem about three times larger.

EXHIBIT 3**Youth unemployment is about three times the national rate and rising**

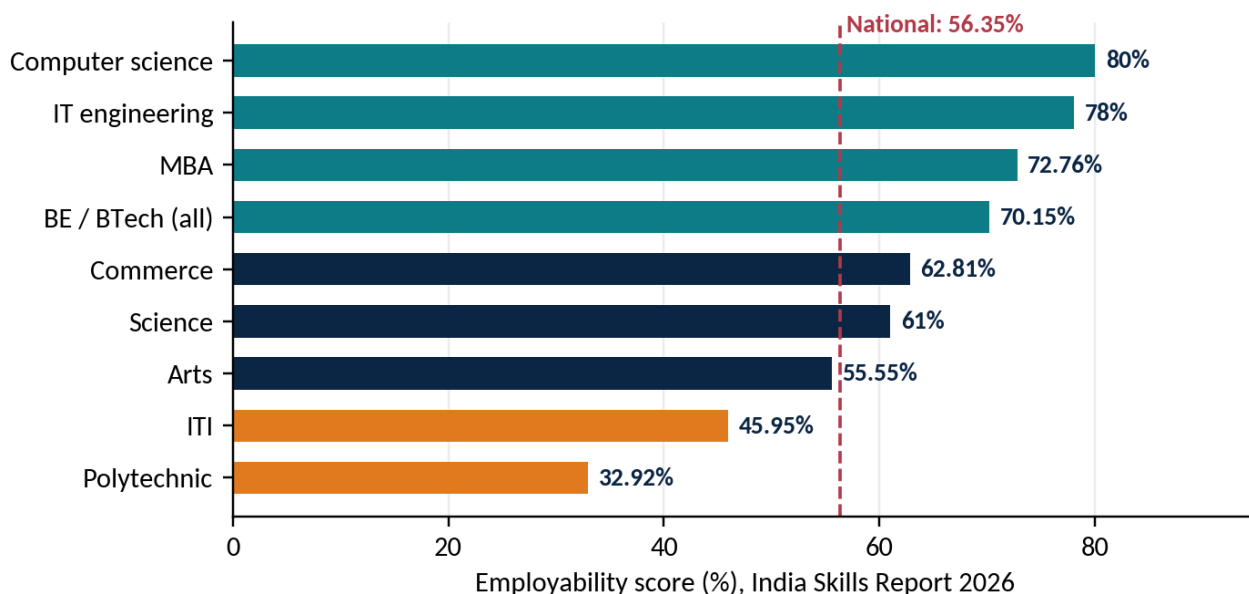
Source: MoSPI, PLFS Quarterly Bulletin April–June 2026 and Monthly Bulletins (Current Weekly Status), as reported by The Policy Edge and Civildaily. Series revamped in January 2025; not comparable with earlier PLFS rounds.

Skills and stream matter, and they are uneven. In the India Skills Report 2026 (an industry-sponsored assessment, so read as indicative), employability is 80% for computer-science graduates but 32.9% for polytechnic and 46% for ITI graduates; overall employability has risen from 46.2% in 2022 to 56.35% in 2026. The spread between streams is exactly the information a student at Grade 10 rarely has.

EXHIBIT 4

Employability varies by 47 percentage points across streams

Employability score by graduate stream, 2026



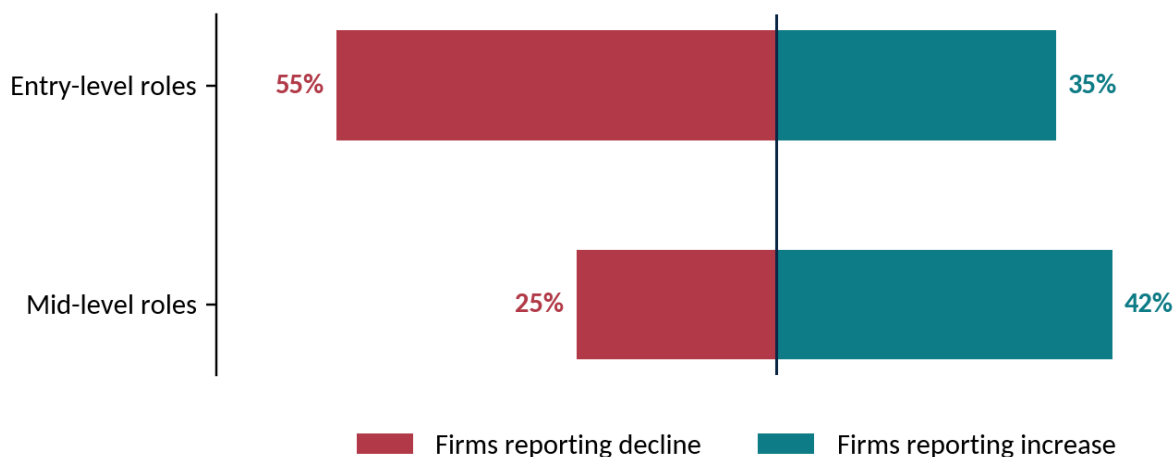
Source: India Skills Report 2026 (Wheebox/ETS with CII, AICTE, AIU, Taggd), Global Employability Test, over 1 lakh candidates; reported by Careers360 and AffairsCloud. An employability score is not an employment rate.

Generative AI is changing the first rung of the ladder. The February 2026 ICRIER study of 651 IT firms in ten cities found that firms are moderating hiring mainly at entry level while demand for mid-level skills rises and senior employment is stable (82% report no change). Nomura analysis reported in August 2026 counted 83,100 AI-related hires against 31,921 AI-linked layoffs and attrition in India, a ratio of about 2.6 to 1, but cautioned that displaced workers are rarely those hired. The World Bank's World Development Report 2026, as reported, estimates AI could perform 9–17% of tasks in India's non-agricultural workforce, reshaping roles more than eliminating them.

EXHIBIT 5

Entry-level roles are where AI-driven hiring moderation is concentrated

Share of IT firms reporting a change in headcount by seniority



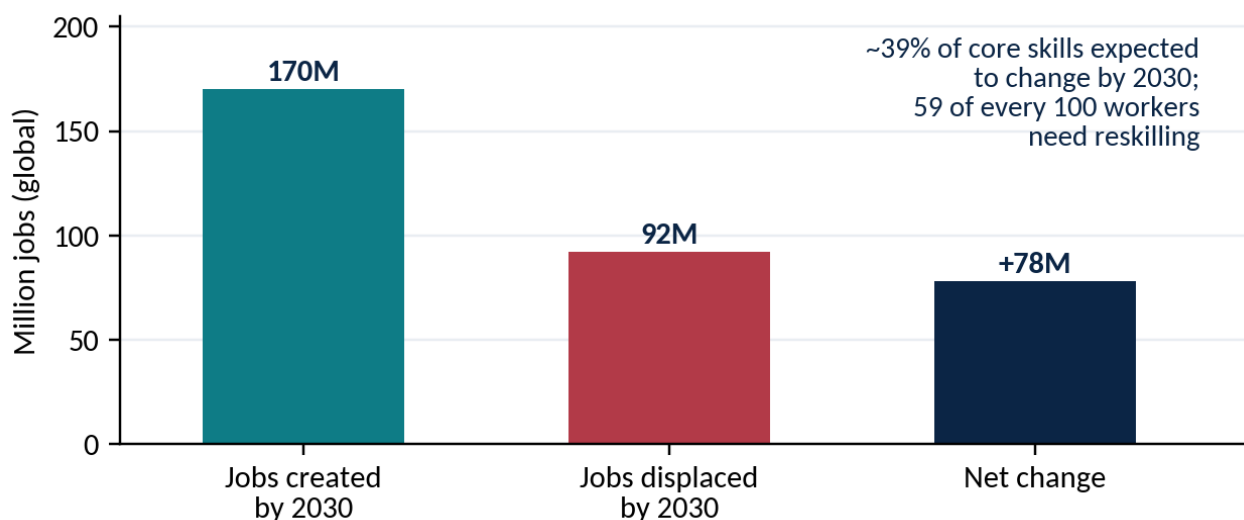
Source: ICRIER, AI and Jobs: This Time Is No Different (February 2026); survey of 651 IT firms, November 2025–January 2026. Senior roles: 82% of firms report no change. Remaining firms report no change at entry and mid levels.

The global picture points the same way. The World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report 2025 projects 170 million jobs created and 92 million displaced by 2030 (net +78 million), with about 39% of workers' core skills changing and 59% of workers needing reskilling. The lesson for guidance is that a one-time stream choice matters less than the ability to keep re-choosing, which is what a longitudinal counselling relationship and a portfolio of transferable skills build.

EXHIBIT 6

Churn, not collapse: large job creation alongside large displacement

Projected global job creation and displacement by 2030, million jobs



Source: World Economic Forum, Future of Jobs Report 2025 (1,000+ employers, 55 economies); global figures.

1.4 The human cost: student distress is rising

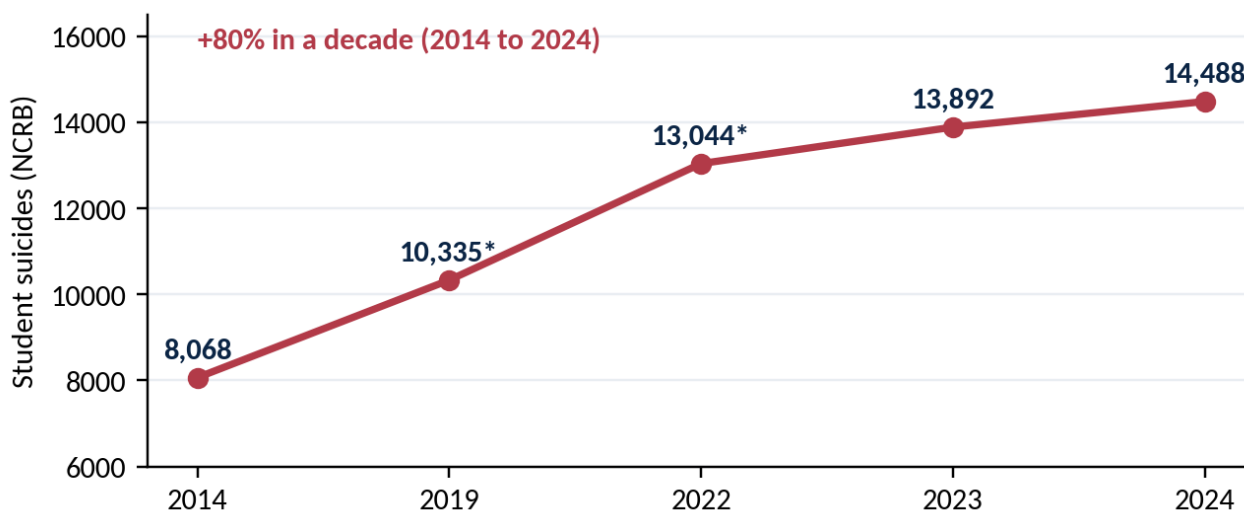
NCRB data show student suicides rising from 8,068 in 2014 to 13,892 in 2023 (8.1% of all suicides) and 14,488 in 2024, a rise of about 80% in a decade that outpaces the growth in overall suicides. In 2024, 2,032 student suicides (14%) were attributed to examination failure, and a handful of states and coaching hubs account for about half of the total. The National Mental Health Survey (2015–16) found that 7.3% of 13–17 year-olds (about 9.8 million) had a mental disorder, with prevalence about twice as high in urban (13.5%) as rural areas (6.9%), and treatment gaps above 60% for most disorders.

Career guidance does not cause or cure these outcomes, and NCRB records a single stated reason per death, which understates complexity. But a system that makes a binary, high-stakes selection at 15–17 with little support will predictably amplify distress. Guidance that lowers the stakes of any single decision (a primary and a backup, a revisable plan) and that has a counsellor already trusted when distress appears is part of the protective architecture.

EXHIBIT 7

Student suicides have risen about 80% in a decade

Student suicides recorded by NCRB



Source: NCRB, Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India (2014, 2023, 2024 as reported by Careers360 and The Wire). *2019 and 2022 values derived from reported growth rates and approximate. If you or someone you know is in distress, Tele-MANAS (14416) offers free, 24-hour support.

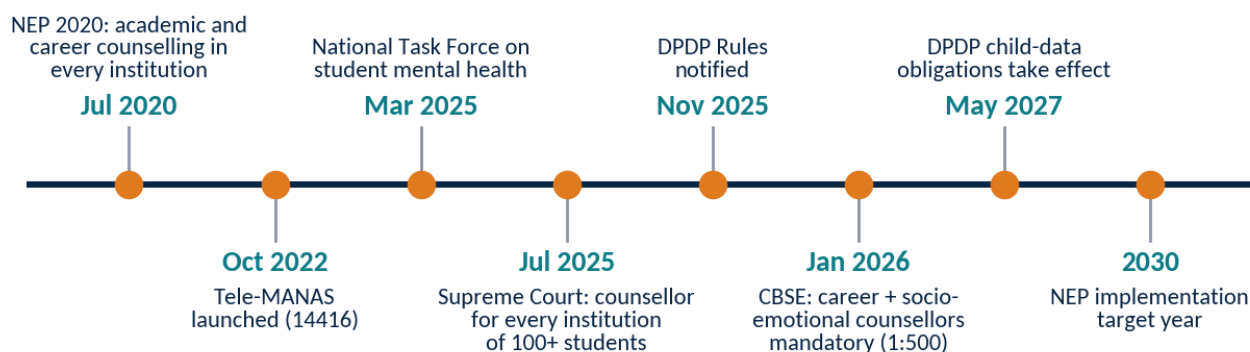
1.5 A policy window has opened

The mandate side of the problem has moved quickly. The 2025 Supreme Court guidelines (*Sukdeb Saha v. State of Andhra Pradesh*, 2025 INSC 893) require a uniform mental-health policy and at least one qualified counsellor, psychologist or social worker in every institution with 100 or more students, with referral linkages for smaller ones. In January 2026 CBSE amended its Affiliation Bye-Laws to require one socio-emotional counsellor per 500 students and a career counsellor (1:500 for Classes 9–12), with a 50-hour recognised training programme and a hub-and-spoke model for small schools. NEP 2020 had already committed every institution to academic and career counselling.

EXHIBIT 8

Mandates are arriving faster than capacity

Policy milestones relevant to career guidance



Source: NEP 2020 (MoE); Tele-MANAS (MoHFW); Supreme Court, 2025 INSC 893; DPDP Rules 2025 (MeitY); CBSE circular of 19 January 2026. Dates of the Task Force and Court order as reported.

So what for decision-makers

The case for guidance no longer rests on aspiration. It rests on a quantifiable decision-quality problem, a weakening entry-level market, a well-being cost and now a legal mandate. The open questions are **how many counsellors, of what quality, funded how, and proven how**. The rest of this handbook answers them.

PART I | THE CASE FOR ACTION

2. The supply gap and the economics

At CBSE's ratio India needs more than a lakh career counsellors for Classes 9–12. The question is which model gets there affordably.

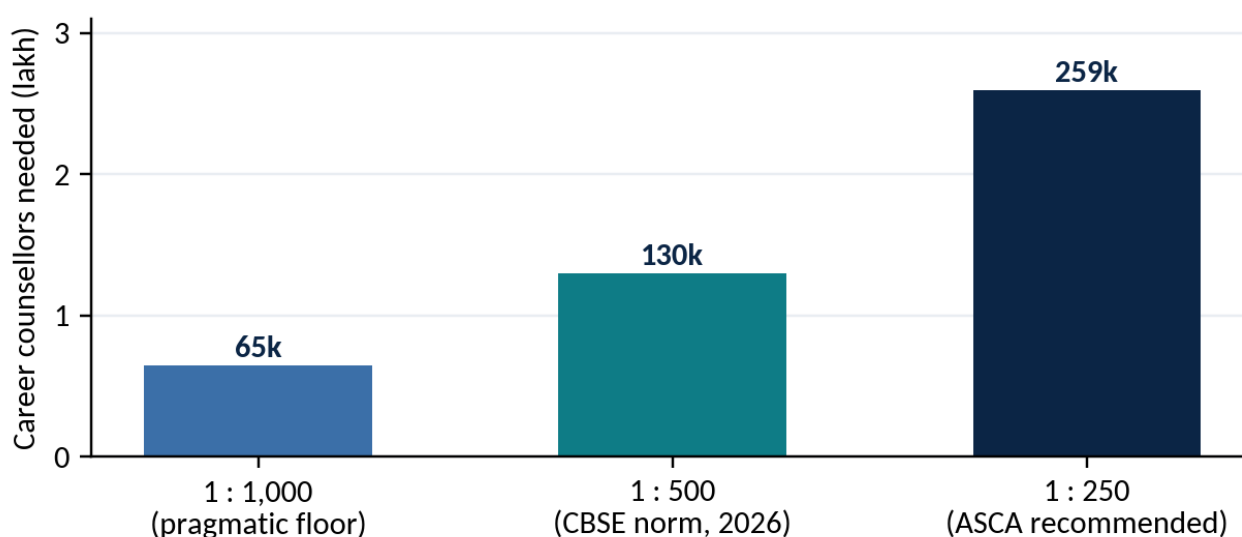
2.1 Sizing the requirement

UDISE+ 2024-25 records about 3.72 crore students in Classes 9–10 and 2.76 crore in Classes 11–12, a combined 6.48 crore. Applying alternative ratios gives the requirement for career counsellors alone. Socio-emotional counsellors (also 1:500 under the CBSE norm) are a separate cadre and are not included, nor are the 4.5 crore students in higher education (AISHE 2023-24).

EXHIBIT 9

Between 65,000 and 2.6 lakh career counsellors are needed for Classes 9–12

Career counsellors required at alternative student-to-counsellor ratios (lakh)



Source: Calculated by this handbook from UDISE+ 2024-25 enrolment (Classes 9–12: 6.48 crore). The 1:500 norm is CBSE's (January 2026); 1:250 is the American School Counselor Association recommendation cited in the original handbook; 1:1,000 is an illustrative pragmatic floor.

Treat widely quoted ratios with caution

Figures such as “one counsellor per 3,000 students”, “93% of schools have no dedicated counsellor” and “a shortage of 15 lakh counsellors” circulate in vendor and press material. We could not trace them to a primary dataset, and the last depends entirely on the ratio assumed. The honest position is that India has **no authoritative census of practising counsellors**. A registry (Chapter 9) is a prerequisite for managing supply.

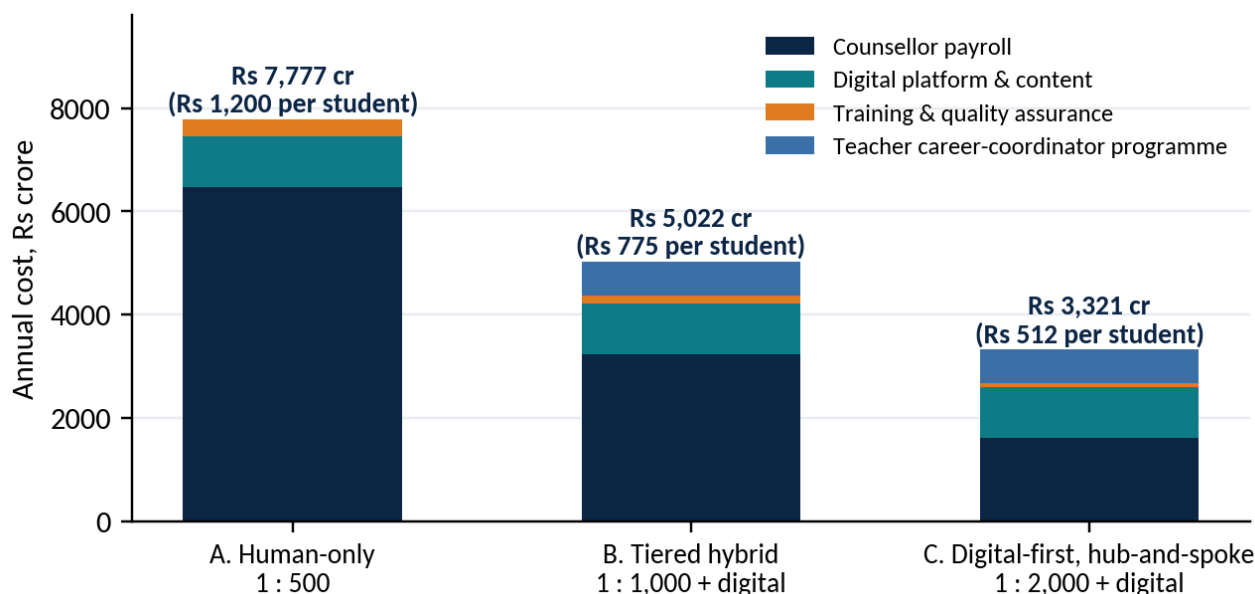
2.2 Three delivery models, three cost profiles

Cost depends far more on delivery design than on salary. The exhibit below compares three illustrative models for Classes 9–12 using explicit assumptions (Appendix C): a fully-loaded cost of ₹5 lakh per counsellor-year, a digital platform at ₹150 per student, training and quality assurance at 5% of payroll, and a teacher career-coordinator programme at ₹100 per student.

EXHIBIT 10

A tiered hybrid model costs about one-third less than human-only and reaches every student

Annual cost by delivery model, ₹ crore



Source: Illustrative planning model by this handbook ($\pm 30\%$). Excludes socio-emotional counsellors, colleges, capital works and one-time set-up. Assumptions in Appendix C. 1 crore = 10 million.

Model	Design logic	Strength	Weakness
A. Human-only, 1:500	Every student gets counsellor time; no structured digital layer	Highest personal touch; matches mandate literally	Most expensive; supply-constrained; uneven quality; idle capacity for students who need little
B. Tiered hybrid, 1:1,000	Universal digital career education and teacher coordinators (Tier 1); counsellor time at decision points (Tier 2) and for high-need students (Tier 3)	Targets scarce expert time; scalable; builds data for evaluation	Needs teacher training and good digital content; requires discipline to protect Tier 3
C. Digital-first hub-and-spoke, 1:2,000	Remote counsellors serve clusters of small or rural schools; teacher coordinators on site	Only viable route to remote areas near-term	Lower contact; connectivity and language barriers; risk of becoming a lesser service for the poorest

Our view. Model B is the sensible national default, with Model C as the delivery variant for sparsely populated and low-connectivity districts and with explicit budget protection for Tier 3 so that digital efficiencies do not quietly thin out support for the students who need it most. At roughly ₹775 per student per year (about US\$9) the tiered model is a small fraction of what many families already spend on coaching, though we have not independently verified coaching expenditure and do not rest the case on it.

2.3 Why we do not publish a benefit–cost ratio

It would be easy to claim a return by assuming a reduction in dropouts or wasted coaching spend. We have not, because no Indian causal evidence supports a specific effect size, and a number invented to close a business case would mislead the decision it is meant to inform. Instead the roadmap makes producing that evidence a Gate-2 condition. The benefit logic we expect to test is below.

Benefit pathway	Mechanism	How it would be measured
Better stream and course fit	Information and self-knowledge reduce mismatch	Grade-11 stream switches; first-year undergraduate dropout or branch change
Smoother school-to-work transition	Earlier exploration, skills and exposure	Time to first paid work; NEET share at 21 (matched cohorts)

Benefit pathway	Mechanism	How it would be measured
Lower decision-related distress	Lower-stakes, revisable choices; trusted adult	Validated wellbeing scales; help-seeking; referral timeliness
Equity of access	Tier 3 targeting; remote delivery	Gap in plan-quality and session access by gender, caste, income, district
System efficiency	Fewer repeated attempts and late pivots	Repeater share in competitive exams; seat-vacancy rates in less-subscribed programmes

PART II | WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

3. What the evidence says works

International research is encouraging, Indian evidence is thin, and the design implication is to build in evaluation from the start.

3.1 The international evidence

The OECD's Career Readiness programme has analysed longitudinal datasets from multiple countries (including 10 new datasets from eight countries in a 2021 working paper) and concluded that international evidence supports 11 of 14 candidate indicators of teenage career readiness. Secondary students who explore, experience and think about their futures in work tend to see lower unemployment, higher wages and greater career satisfaction as adults. Three findings matter for India.

- **Exposure beats information alone.** Activities that put teenagers in contact with the world of work (career talks, job fairs, workplace visits, part-time work, employer contact) are associated with better later outcomes. OECD analysis of PISA data finds that fewer than 40% of 15-year-olds on average had attended a job fair. Brochures and tests are necessary but insufficient.
- **Guidance can compensate for disadvantage.** Teenagers from disadvantaged backgrounds are least likely to have a career conversation with an adult, yet the evidence suggests well-designed guidance can partly offset the gap. That is the equity argument for Tier 3.
- **Alignment, breadth and realism matter.** Narrow occupational expectations concentrated in a few well-known jobs, or expectations misaligned with planned education, are associated with worse transitions. This is a direct description of India's herding problem.

What the evidence does not show

These are associations from observational longitudinal data. Students who seek out career activities may differ in unmeasured ways. The research supports investing in guidance and tells us *which kinds* of activity are promising; it does not give an effect size for India, and it was gathered in labour markets and school systems very different from ours.

3.2 How other systems organise guidance

No country has a perfect model, but the better systems share three traits: guidance is a statutory entitlement across the school years, delivery is split between trained teachers and specialist counsellors, and a shared occupational information system underpins it. The comparison below is drawn from public descriptions and the original handbook; verify specifics before quoting in formal documents.

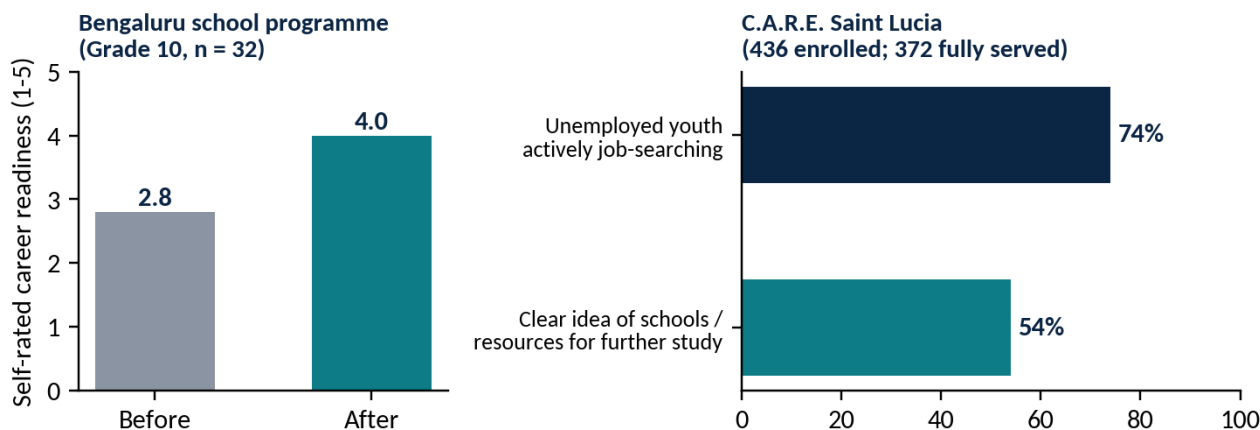
System	Model in brief	Lesson for India
England	Eight Gatsby Benchmarks define a stable careers programme; each school has a named Careers Leader; employer encounters and workplace experiences are expected	A benchmarked standard plus a named accountable lead is cheaper to roll out than a counsellor per school
Germany	Schools responsible for guidance through all years; trained teachers, social workers, school psychologists and vocational practitioners; free employment-agency guidance; young jobseekers under 25 served by a dedicated unit with about 75 young people per case manager	Division of labour across professions, and a smooth hand-off from school to employment services
United States	ASCA recommends 1:250; many states require career and academic planning from middle school; state-wide computer-assisted career guidance systems are built on the free O*NET occupational database	A public occupational database is infrastructure that every provider can build on
Finland and Singapore	Statutory guidance counselling in Finnish comprehensive schools; Singapore's Education and Career Guidance programme combines school counsellors with a national student portal	Guidance as a defined entitlement with a national digital layer
India today	NEP 2020 commitment; Supreme Court and CBSE mandates; National Career Service portal; fragmented private providers; no national competency or validation standard	Mandates exist; standards, supply and evidence do not yet

3.3 Evidence from practice, and how to read it

The original handbook offered two programme case studies. They are useful illustrations of design, and we retain them, with the caveat that neither is a controlled evaluation.

EXHIBIT 11

Both programmes report encouraging self-reported gains, from small or uncontrolled samples



Source: *Delivering Career Guidance: Case Study of a School-Based Method from India* (2015), Sri Kumaran Children's Home, Bengaluru (n = 32, self-rated, no comparison group); *International Youth Foundation, Career Guidance Case Study* (2013), C.A.R.E., Saint Lucia (436 enrolled, 372 received the full service; external follow-up study). Both as summarised in the original handbook.

- **Sri Kumaran (Bengaluru).** A year-long Grade-10 programme combined workshops, an expert-administered aptitude test, a "Potential Profile", a parent orientation, three career-research assignments and two Career Days. Self-rated readiness rose from 2.8 to 4.0 on a five-point scale. Design lesson: the parents were treated as partners, and the report was followed by one-to-one sessions.
- **C.A.R.E. (Saint Lucia).** A 145-hour, six-week programme for at-risk youth aged 17–25 combined life-skills training (49 hours), psychometric testing, career-plan and job-readiness workshops, one-to-one coaching and psychosocial support. 74% of unemployed participants were actively job-searching and 54% had a clear idea of further-study options. Design lesson: for disadvantaged youth, life skills and psychosocial support were rated most useful, ahead of assessment.

What a credible Indian evaluation looks like

- **Design:** matched-comparison schools or randomised phase-in across 300 pilot schools in three states, with a pre-registered plan.
- **Outcomes:** stream-fit and Grade-11 switching, first-year undergraduate persistence, plan quality, wellbeing, and, for the 12th-grade cohort, 24-month transition outcomes.
- **Governance:** independent evaluator; results published irrespective of direction; equity cuts by gender, caste, income and district.
- **Cost:** roughly 3–5% of programme budget, an inexpensive way to avoid scaling something that does not work.

3.4 Four stories, one lesson: late discovery is the common cost

The original handbook used four individual stories. Re-read as case evidence, they show four distinct failure and recovery patterns, each pointing at a specific intervention.

Story	What happened	Pattern	Intervention that would have helped
Ashish (CA, small-town Gujarat, 1960s)	Never knew the civil services existed; regretted it for life	Information gap	Occupational information system; role-model access
Aakansha (science to psychology)	A test surfaced sport as an option; at 18 she felt it was too late. Found fit in clinical psychology later	Late and narrow	Assessment at Grade 8–9, not post-12th; links to non-academic careers; skills-over-marks coaching

Story	What happened	Pattern	Intervention that would have helped
Sushant (CA and economist)	Followed marks into science, then CA; self-corrected via reading, internships, backup plans	Self-correction through exposure	Make exposure and backup planning routine rather than luck
Shraddha (microbiologist to fashion stylist)	A gap year and internships revealed the career she did not know had a name	Hidden option	Workplace exposure and mentors; legitimate gap-year and pivot narrative for parents

Two of the four self-corrected through mentors and internships, which are free of cost to the system but gated by social capital. The case for structured guidance is largely a case for giving every student what the well-connected already get informally.

PART II | WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

4. The science of fit: assessments graded by evidence

The 3-Dimensional Awareness model stands. The tools inside it are not equally trustworthy, and decision-makers should know which are which.

4.1 The framework, restated

The original handbook re-articulates Frank Parsons's 1909 insight as three kinds of awareness: of oneself, of the career landscape, and of the right fit between them, followed by an assessment of 21st-century skills. This remains the right organising idea. We add one refinement: a student's *circumstances* (finance, geography, family, health) are a fourth input to the fit, not a footnote. The best recommendation for a student is the best *achievable* one.

Dimension	What it covers	Typical instruments	Use with care because
1. Know yourself	Interests, personality, aptitude, values, strengths, life story and circumstances	Holland RIASEC; Big Five; aptitude batteries; structured interview	Adolescent interests and personality are still forming; scores are hypotheses to revisit, not verdicts
2. Know the landscape	Occupations, industries, skills in demand, automation exposure, academic routes, entrance exams, funding	Occupational information system; career demos; mentors; workplace visits	Data goes stale fast; must be maintained and open to audit
3. Know the fit	Matching of self and landscape; realistic primary and backup options	Counsellor judgement supported by matching algorithms	Algorithms inherit biases in their inputs; the student must own the decision
4. Build the skills	21st-century and AI-era skills needed to thrive in the chosen path	Skills portfolio; project and internship evidence	Skills are shown in behaviour, not tests alone

4.2 Not all instruments are equal

The original lists many instruments side by side. Our qualitative synthesis of the psychometric literature grades them on five criteria. Two conclusions stand out. First, interest inventories (RIASEC), the Big Five and aptitude batteries have the strongest evidence and are appropriate foundations. Second, three widely marketed tools should not carry weight in career recommendations: Multiple Intelligences inventories (useful as a reflective vocabulary, but without empirical support as distinct, measurable intelligences or as predictors of career success), MBTI (limited reliability and predictive validity) and the Rorschach and MMPI (clinical instruments requiring qualified clinicians, which the original lists among tools counsellors can use).

EXHIBIT 12**Interest, Big Five and aptitude tools have the strongest evidence; MI, MBTI and projective tests are weak bases for recommendations**

Evidence strength by instrument and criterion

	Predictive validity	Reliability	India norms / adaptation	Adolescent suitability	Scalability
Holland RIASEC (interest)	Moderate	Good	Moderate	Good	Strong
Big Five / OCEAN (personality)	Good	Good	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
Aptitude batteries (DAT, GATB)	Good	Good	Moderate	Good	Moderate
Multiple Intelligences inventories	Weak	Limited	Limited	Moderate	Strong
MBTI	Limited	Limited	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
Rorschach / MMPI	Weak	Limited	Weak	Weak	Weak

Source: Author's qualitative synthesis of the psychometric literature; judgement-based and not a formal meta-analysis. India-norm ratings reflect availability of published Indian validation, which varies by instrument and publisher.

Six principles for using assessment with minors

- **Inform, never decide.** Results frame a conversation; they are never presented as a verdict on a child.
- **Triangulate.** Combine at least interest, aptitude and personality evidence with the student's story, grades and circumstances.
- **Re-assess.** Repeat at roughly Grades 8–9, 10 and 12. Interests and personality continue to develop through adolescence; the original's claim that aptitudes are fixed by 13–14 and cannot be improved overstates the evidence.
- **Norm and adapt for India.** Require published Indian norms, language coverage and accessibility for students with disabilities.
- **Offer a range.** Report three to five options with rationale, and always one backup. A single "best" career is false precision.
- **Audit for bias.** Matching algorithms must be tested for gender, caste, region and income skew before deployment and annually after.

4.3 The occupational information gap

The United States built its guidance systems on a free national occupational database (O*NET) that any provider can use. India has fragments: the National Classification of Occupations, NSQF qualifications, the National Career Service portal and a long tail of private databases, but no single open, regularly refreshed layer linking occupations to skills, pathways, colleges, entrance exams and salary ranges. The original handbook rightly identifies this as a barrier. We make it a priority: an **open national occupational and pathways dataset** (with an API) would let providers compete on counselling quality and user experience rather than on who has scraped the most career profiles.

Two features should be mandatory in that dataset. The first is an AI-exposure and outlook indicator per occupation, updated annually; students should not be steered into declining roles. The second is explicit coverage of non-traditional and vocational paths, to support the NEP's aim of removing the status hierarchy between academic and vocational education.

PART II | WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

5. The student journey and the counselling process

Career choice is a process across nine years, not an event in one afternoon. The unit of design is the journey.

5.1 A journey from awareness to launch

The original handbook argues that career counselling should start in Grade 8 (age 13) and continue through college, with light career awareness from about age 11. We agree and have turned the argument into a stage-gated programme. The research logic is simple: students plan, persist and engage more at school when they can link effort to a tentative goal, and a long runway allows interests to be tested and revised before decisions become costly.

EXHIBIT 13

A stage-gated journey, with defined activities at each grade band

Proposed guidance programme by stage

	Gr 6-7 Awareness (play, stories)	Gr 8-9 Discover (self + careers)	Gr 10 Stream decision	Gr 11-12 Narrow & prepare	College Experience & launch
Assess	Interest screener (light)	Full 3-D assessment #1	Re-assess (aptitude + values)	Gap & fit check for entrance routes	Reflect on experience
Explore	Stories, role plays, hobbies	Career demos, professional talks	Subject-to-career mapping	Entrance exams, colleges, funding	Internships, projects, mentors
Decide	-	Hypotheses (3-5 options)	Stream choice with parents (1 primary + 1 backup)	Course + college shortlist	Specialisation, first job / study
Skills	Curiosity, communication	Study habits, teamwork	Decision-making, stress mgmt	Leadership, digital + AI fluency	Employability, entrepreneurship
Well-being	Emotional literacy	Screen for stress	Exam-stress protocol, referral	Transition support	Counsellor check-ins

Source: Adapted and extended by this handbook from the learning journey in the original ProTeen handbook (Chapter 6); NEP 2020 stage structure.

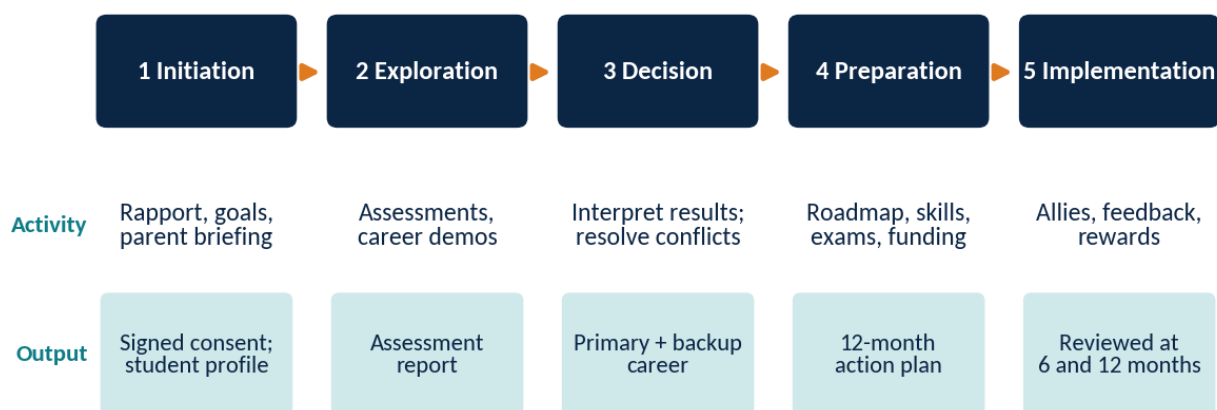
- **Grades 6–7: awareness.** Children are in “play” mode and know a handful of high-visibility careers. Widen the vocabulary through stories, role play and exposure, and begin emotional-literacy skills.
- **Grades 8–9: discover.** The first full assessment, career demos and professional talks. The aim is a shortlist of three to five hypotheses, not a decision. Praise for what a child is good at helps them name their interests.
- **Grade 10: decide the stream.** The highest-stakes touchpoint. Re-assess, map subjects to careers, and hold a joint student–parent session that ends in one primary and one backup route.
- **Grades 11–12: narrow and prepare.** Entrance-exam routes, college shortlists, funding and scholarships, and a realistic reading of the student’s academic record against their ambitions.
- **College: experience and launch.** Internships, projects and mentors matter as much as the college name; the second assessment point is reflection on experience, then specialisation and first job or further study.

5.2 The counselling process: five stages

The five stages of the original handbook (initiation, exploration, decision-making, preparation, implementation) map well to international practice. What the original left implicit, and we make explicit, is that each stage must have a **defined output** that can be inspected and measured. Without that, “counselling” degenerates into a test report and a handshake, which is the pattern the original itself criticises.

EXHIBIT 14

Each stage of counselling should produce a checkable output



Source: Adapted from the five-stage process in the original ProTeen handbook (Chapter 8); outputs and review points added by this handbook.

5.3 Principles that separate good from mechanical counselling

- **Therapeutic alliance first.** Trust takes time and is the precondition for honest disclosure. Skipping rapport is the most common failure the original identifies. Strengths-based framing works better than dwelling on deficits.
- **Build self-efficacy.** Bandura's four sources (personal accomplishment, role models, encouragement, calm physiological state) can be designed into the programme: small wins, exposure to relatable professionals, specific praise and exam-stress skills.
- **Treat parents as partners.** Parents usually have the final say. Counsellors need to brief them on the science, the options and the backup plan, and mediate gently where a student's inclinations and family expectations diverge. A parent session at each decision point is a minimum standard.
- **Protect the unglamorous work.** Extra-curricular activity is not a distraction. It underpins early skills, side-interests and later pivots, and is routinely sacrificed in Grades 10–12.
- **Keep a documented, revisable plan.** A 12-month action plan, reviewed at six and twelve months, turns insight into behaviour.

A proposed minimum contact standard (for pilot testing)

- **Tier 1 (all students):** two career periods a term in Grades 8–12; one digital assessment per decision point; one group session per term.
- **Tier 2:** at least one individual counsellor session and one parent session at each of Grades 9, 10 and 12, plus a college-entry session.
- **Tier 3:** six or more sessions a year, proactive check-ins and family engagement.

These are proposals to be tuned in the pilot, not evidence-based thresholds.

PART II | WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

6. Skills for an AI-shaped labour market

Credentials get a student to the interview. Adaptability and demonstrated skills get them the job, and keep it.

The original handbook identifies twelve 21st-century skills in three groups (empowerment, excellence, employability), drawn from UNICEF, WHO and WEF frameworks. We keep that structure and update the weighting for an AI-shaped market. The World Economic Forum's 2025 outlook places AI and big-data skills, networks and cybersecurity, technological literacy, creative thinking and resilience, flexibility and agility among the fastest-growing skill demands to 2030, while manual dexterity and routine clerical skills decline.

Group	Skills in the original handbook	What changes in 2026	Example evidence of the skill
Empowerment	Self-awareness; effective communication; emotional intelligence; stress management	Resilience and learning agility rise in importance as roles churn; communication now includes writing and working with AI tools	Reflective journal; peer feedback; conflict handled in a team project
Excellence	Critical thinking; creative thinking; problem-solving and decision-making; social and interpersonal skills	Critical thinking becomes the guard against over-trusting AI output; analytical thinking is a top employer-reported skill	Evaluating a source set; a documented decision with alternatives and criteria
Employability	Technological literacy; service orientation; entrepreneurship; leadership	Add AI fluency and data literacy as an explicit skill; entrepreneurship and portfolio work matter more as entry-level roles compress	Project portfolio; use of AI tools with documented checks; a small venture or club

- **When to build them.** The original places the ideal window at ages 10–14, when identity forms and students remain impressionable. NEP 2020 supports this through experiential, art- and sports-integrated learning.
- **How to assess them.** Portfolios, projects and observed behaviour, not multiple-choice tests. Skills that are tested become skills that are gamed.
- **Where entry-level roles are compressing,** internships, apprenticeships and real projects substitute for the on-the-job learning that used to come in the first year of work. The PM Internship Scheme and employer partnerships are natural vehicles; schools should be able to broker them.
- **Teach the skill of choosing.** Decision-making under uncertainty, comfort with backup plans, and the habit of testing a hypothesis cheaply are the most transferable outputs of good guidance.

A note on the gig economy and entrepreneurship

The original handbook enthusiastically promotes portfolio careers, freelancing and entrepreneurship. These are real options for some students, but the handbook cites mostly US and anecdotal evidence for the scale of the gig economy. Guidance should present them honestly, including income volatility and the absence of social protection, rather than as a default.

PART II | WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

7. Well-being and safeguarding

Career counsellors are not clinicians, but they are often the first adult to notice distress. The system must be designed for that.

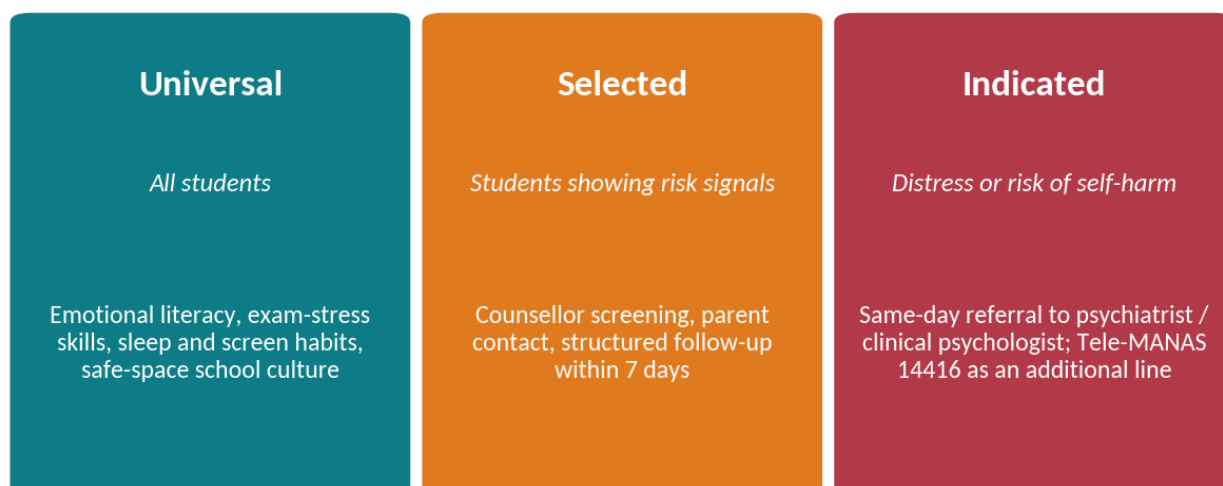
The original handbook argues that career and personal counselling are intertwined and that career counsellors should have a working understanding of adolescent mental health, referring to others where problems exceed their competence. We agree, and add what policy now requires. The Supreme Court's 2025 guidelines mandate a uniform mental-health policy, qualified counsellors, referral protocols, staff training and parent sensitisation; they treat mental health as part of the right to life under Article 21.

The WHO estimates (as cited in the original) that one in seven 10–19 year-olds globally experiences a mental disorder, and that suicide is the fourth leading cause of death among 15–19 year-olds. India's own survey data (NMHS 2015–16) give 7.3% for 13–17 year-olds, with a treatment gap above 60% for most disorders. Tele-MANAS, the national tele-mental-health service (toll-free 14416, 20 languages), had handled more than 29.8 lakh calls by November 2025, evidence of both demand and a usable referral channel.

EXHIBIT 15

A stepped-care model places the career counsellor at the first two levels and defines the hand-off

Three levels of student well-being support



Source: Structure adapted by this handbook from public-health stepped-care practice; Tele-MANAS (MoHFW) as the national referral line; Supreme Court guidelines 2025 for institutional duties.

- **Boundaries.** A career counsellor recognises and escalates; she does not diagnose or treat. Written protocols must say who to call, within what time, and who informs parents.
- **Same-day escalation** for any disclosure of self-harm intent, with a named clinical contact in or linked to the institution. Smaller institutions use the referral linkages the Court requires.
- **Lower the stakes.** Design the programme so that no single decision feels final: primary plus backup, a revisable plan, the framing that a first choice is a hypothesis. NEP's move to twice-yearly board exams points the same way.
- **Prevention skills for everyone.** The original's preventive measures (sleep, exercise and food, early breaks, mindfulness, limited social media, boundaries, naming emotions without judgement, seeking help) are sound and belong in Tier 1.
- **Look after counsellors.** Empathy without reciprocity produces burnout. Caseload caps, regular clinical supervision and peer communities are a quality-assurance measure, not a perk.

PART II | WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

8. Technology, data and ethics

Technology makes scale possible. It also makes scale dangerous if the tools are unvalidated or the data is mishandled.

8.1 What technology should do, and not do

The original handbook's case for digitising assessment is persuasive. Manual instruments can run to hundreds of items over two and a half hours, producing fatigue and scoring errors; digital delivery allows breaks, instant scoring and consistent administration; career information can be offered as text and video, and career demos let students sample roles from home. Its counsellors report concerns that online tools cannot capture what a human sees (tone, body language); the answer is a **high-tech, high-touch** design in which technology handles administration, scoring and information, and humans handle interpretation, relationship and judgement.

One caution. The original supports digital equivalence with a single practitioner's anecdote that manual and digital administration gave the same results. That is not evidence. Procurement should require published psychometric-equivalence studies.

8.2 A procurement checklist for any guidance platform

Criterion	What to ask for
Validity and reliability	Published evidence for each instrument; predictive-validity data; Indian norms; date of last norming
Fairness	Independent bias audit for gender, caste, region and income; disclosure of how matching works; annual re-audit
Transparency	Explainable recommendations (the "why" for each suggested career); no black-box single score
Human in the loop	Counsellor interpretation step before results reach a student; escalation rules for distress signals
Content quality	Occupational data with dated sources and an owner; AI-exposure indicator; coverage of vocational and non-traditional paths
Access	Coverage of Indian languages; accessibility for students with disabilities; low-bandwidth and offline modes
Data protection	Data minimisation; verifiable parental consent; no behavioural tracking or advertising to children; deletion on request; breach reporting
Portability and openness	Student-owned record that can move between providers; open APIs; no lock-in
Commercial terms	Transparent pricing; no commission steering students to particular colleges or coaching providers; disclosure of conflicts

8.3 Children's data: the legal context

The Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 and the DPDP Rules 2025 (notified November 2025) require verifiable parental consent before processing the personal data of anyone under 18 and prohibit tracking, behavioural monitoring and targeted advertising directed at children. The substantive obligations take effect on 14 May 2027. The Rules exempt some classes of fiduciary, including educational institutions, where processing is limited to defined purposes, but this should not be read as a blanket exemption for commercial vendors working with schools. Career guidance data is unusually sensitive: it can include psychological profiles, family circumstances and health disclosures, and it persists for years. Our recommendation is to adopt the DPDP standard as binding from the first pilot, not from the legal deadline.

8.4 Generative AI in counselling

AI assistants will be used by students whether or not systems approve them. Safe use rests on four guardrails: they answer from a verified occupational database rather than from open-ended generation; they never diagnose, predict outcomes for an individual or recommend a single path; they hand off to a human on distress signals; and conversations are logged, minimised and protected under the same data standard as any other student record.

8.5 A professional code of ethics

There is no binding national code of ethics for career counsellors in India. The original adapts the Canadian Standards and Guidelines (2004) and the UK Career Development Institute code (2012). We retain its twelve commitments and translate them into what an inspector could check.

Principle	What it means operationally
Responsibility, transparency, integrity, objectivity	Disclose conflicts, fees and any commercial relationship with colleges or coaching providers
Competence and continuing development	Hold current qualifications; log CPD hours; practise within training
Accurate representation	No guarantees of admission or outcome; marketing claims substantiated
Referral	Written referral protocol; do not manage clinical issues
Impartiality and non-discrimination	Set aside personal values; document diverse-client practice; bias-aware use of tools
Privacy and confidentiality	Disclose what is collected and why; use only for that purpose; secure storage; release only with informed consent or by law; state limits of confidentiality
Minors' rights	Involve parents or guardians where required; respect the child's voice
Autonomy	The student decides; counsellors inform and support
Conflicts of interest	Resolve through consultation and ethical decision-making
Best interests	Act in the client's best interests at all times

PART III | MAKING IT HAPPEN

9. The counsellor workforce

Scale depends on a profession with defined tiers, standards, supervision and a visible career path.

9.1 A three-tier workforce

India currently has no national competency framework for career counsellors, and, as the original handbook notes, no requirement for a psychology background or licence. CBSE's January 2026 circular begins to fix this for socio-emotional counsellors (a psychology degree or a postgraduate degree in social work, plus a mandatory 50-hour recognised programme) and prescribes academic qualifications for career counsellors. A national structure should build on that rather than compete with it. We propose three tiers so that scarce expertise is used where it matters.

Tier	Role	Indicative entry standard (proposed)	Primary service tier
A. Teacher career-coordinator	Delivers career periods, group sessions and digital modules; first-line recognition of distress; links to the counsellor	Serving teacher; recognised foundation programme of at least 50 hours (aligned with CBSE's model); annual refresher	Tier 1 (universal)
B. Career counsellor	Individual and parent sessions at decision points; interprets assessments; builds action plans	Graduate or postgraduate in psychology, education, social work or allied field; diploma or certificate in career counselling; supervised practice hours	Tier 2
C. Senior / clinically-linked counsellor	Complex and Tier-3 cases; supervises Tier B; liaises with clinical services; leads hub schools	Postgraduate psychology or counselling; extended supervised practice; clinical-referral competence	Tier 3, supervision, hub leadership

9.2 Where the supply comes from

- **Pre-service:** career-counselling electives and supervised placements in psychology, education and social-work degrees; the NCERT diploma in guidance and counselling is an existing pathway.
- **In-service:** accredited short programmes to convert teachers into Tier-A coordinators and graduates into Tier-B counsellors. Today's market already offers programmes from several providers and institutes, but we are not aware of a single national accreditation standard, so quality varies and employers cannot compare credentials.
- **Mid-career entrants:** professionals from HR, teaching, social work and industry, with a short bridge course and supervised practice.
- **Remote hub counsellors:** CBSE's hub-and-spoke model lets a trained counsellor in a hub school serve smaller neighbours; this is also the route to rural coverage.
- **A registry and CPD log** so that supply can be counted, quality tracked and misconduct addressed.

9.3 Careers within career counselling

The original lays out routes for counsellors: employment in schools, colleges and organisations; freelance or private practice; establishing a counselling centre; and taking a franchise. We retain the list and add the economics a prospective counsellor, or a funder weighing the supply side, would want to see. There is no authoritative salary benchmark for the profession in India; our model uses ₹3–6 lakh a year fully-loaded as a planning range, to be replaced by registry data.

Route	Capital and effort	Strength	Watch-out
Employed counsellor (school, college, organisation)	Low; steady income; builds supervised hours	Fastest to start; the demand created by the mandates is concentrated here	Role clarity; caseload; counsellor treated as administrator or "spy"
Private practice / freelance	Low to medium; needs brand, assessment toolkit and marketing	Autonomy; flexible hours; online reach	Irregular income; isolation; need to access validated tools

Route	Capital and effort	Strength	Watch-out
Counselling centre	Medium to high; staff, premises, software, marketing	Can offer wider services (admissions, personal counselling)	Business risk; quality control; temptation to over-sell
Franchise	Medium; licence fee and set-up	Brand, tools and referrals supplied	Dependence on the franchisor; make sure tool validity is documented

9.4 Staying current

Counsellors need continuing professional development on the labour market, tools and ethics. The original's list of open sources remains useful: the National Career Development Association, ERIC, JSTOR, Google Scholar and Semantic Scholar for research; National Career Services, Vikaspedia and MSDE for government information; and peer communities of practice. A national community of practice, with supervision groups, would do more for quality than any single course.

PART III | MAKING IT HAPPEN

10. The operating model and investment case

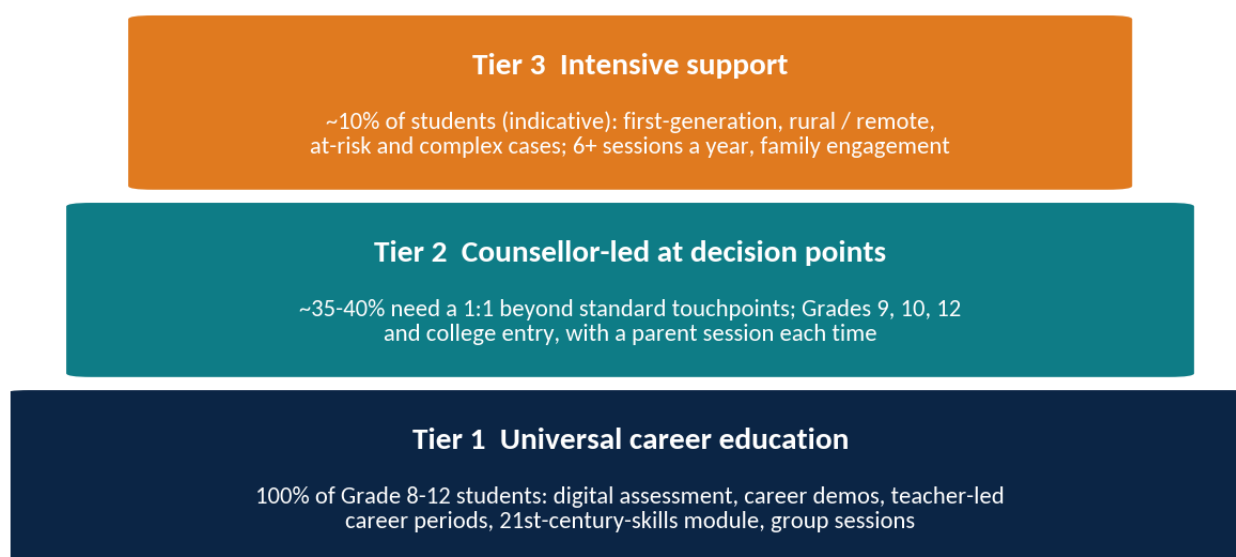
A three-tier service, delivered through hub-and-spoke, funded by shared accountability and run on open standards.

10.1 The tiered service

EXHIBIT 16

Spend expert time where it changes outcomes: universal base, targeted depth

Proposed three-tier service model



Source: Proposed model; tier shares are indicative and to be calibrated in the pilot. Tier 1 service levels follow the minimum contact standard in Chapter 5.

The design logic is simple. Everyone needs a structured base: a validated assessment at decision points, access to credible career information, a skills module and a teacher who has time in the timetable to run it. About a third to two-fifths of students will want or need a one-to-one at the decisive moments. A minority (indicatively 10%) need much more: first-generation learners with no family template, students in remote areas, those with disabilities, and those in distress. The tiered design lets the system reserve its most expensive resource for them.

10.2 Delivery architecture

- **Hub-and-spoke.** A hub school with a Tier-B or C counsellor mentors a cluster of nearby spoke schools, in person and remotely. This is CBSE's model and extends naturally to state boards.
- **A named career lead in every institution.** Borrowing from England's Careers Leader, one accountable person owns the programme, whether or not a counsellor sits on the staff. This can start immediately, before supply arrives.
- **Open standards, competitive market.** The state provides the occupational and pathways dataset, the competency and validation standards, and the registry. Providers compete on counselling and tools. Schools choose from approved providers rather than being locked in.
- **A portable student career record.** Controlled by the student and their family, it holds assessments, plans and portfolio evidence across providers and years. Any link to the national student ID (APAAR) should be consent-based, purpose-limited and compliant with DPDP.

10.3 Who pays

Segment	Suggested funding logic	Rationale
Government and aided schools: Tiers 1 and 2	Public funding through state education budgets and Centrally-sponsored schemes, with hub counsellors shared across schools	Equity; the Court and Board mandates apply regardless of ownership
Private schools: Tiers 1 and 2	School-funded within mandated ratios; approved-provider list; transparent parent communication	Ability to pay; protects against commercial steering
Tier 3 for disadvantaged students	Earmarked public funds plus CSR and philanthropic matching	Highest social return and highest cost per student; the market will under-serve it
Common infrastructure (dataset, registry, evaluation)	National public good funded centrally; independent evaluation funded ring-fenced	Avoids duplicated spending and conflicts of interest

The investment case rests on the unit economics in Chapter 2: a tiered hybrid model at about ₹775 per student per year, and an evaluation that will produce the first Indian causal estimate before scale decisions are taken.

PART III | MAKING IT HAPPEN

11. The decision agenda, by stakeholder

Every stakeholder holds part of the solution. These are the decisions that unlock it in the next twelve months.

Stakeholder	Decisions required (next 12 months)	What they gain	Success measure
Union and state education departments	Fund the 300-school, three-state pilot with independent evaluation; establish the national competency framework and registry within 9 months; commission the open occupational and pathways dataset; protect Tier-3 budgets	Evidence for scale decisions; compliance with Court and NEP commitments	Pilot launched in 6 months; registry live in 9; evaluation plan pre-registered
School boards (CBSE, state boards, ISC, IB)	Adopt the three-tier workforce structure; extend CBSE's hub-and-spoke and 50-hour model to other boards; publish approved-provider criteria	Consistency across boards; defensible affiliation norms	Share of affiliated schools meeting mandate; share using approved tools
Regulators (UGC, AICTE, professional councils)	Include career-guidance outputs in accreditation; commit to publishing programme outcome and persistence data; recognise counsellor credentials	Better-informed intake; lower first-year dropout	Share of HEIs with funded career services; published outcome data
Institution heads	Appoint a career lead now; timetable career periods in Grades 8–12; hold a parent session at each decision point; designate a clinical referral partner	Compliance; lower distress and attrition; stronger placement outcomes	Students with a documented plan; referral time; parent attendance
Industry, CSR and philanthropy	Underwrite Tier 3 and the evaluation; open workplace visits, mentoring and internships to schools; share anonymised skills-demand data	Better-prepared talent pipeline; credible CSR with measurable outcomes	Students reached in Tier 3; mentor and internship hours; evaluation published
Guidance providers and edtech	Publish validity, norming and bias-audit evidence; accept data portability and no-profiling terms; price transparently; join the approved-provider list	Access to the mandated market; trust	Audit published; DPDP compliance; school renewal rates
Parents and communities	Attend decision-point sessions; support a backup plan; protect extra-curricular time; know the referral lines	Better-informed decisions with less conflict	Attendance; satisfaction; student-reported family support
Counsellors and professional bodies	Agree a code of ethics and supervision norms; define CPD; build the community of practice; support the registry	Recognition, standards and a career path	Registered members; CPD completion; complaint resolution

PART III | MAKING IT HAPPEN

12. Roadmap, measures and risks

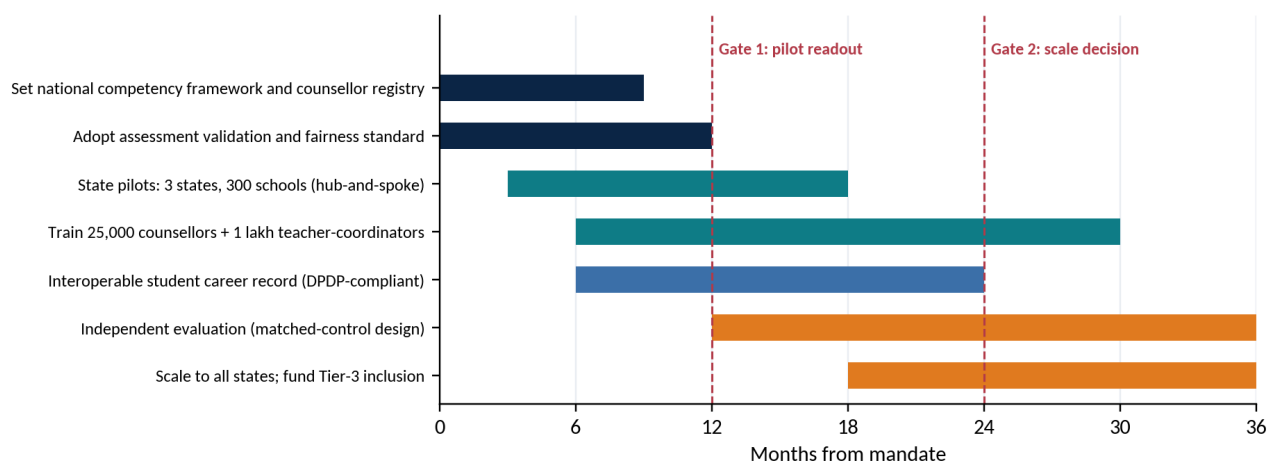
Thirty-six months, two decision gates, and a short list of what can go wrong.

12.1 A 36-month roadmap with two gates

EXHIBIT 17

Standards first, pilot in parallel, evidence before scale

Indicative roadmap, months from mandate



Source: Proposed by this handbook. Counts (300 schools, 25,000 counsellors, 1 lakh teacher-coordinators) are planning targets, not forecasts.

Gate 1 (month 12): pilot readout. Continue only if implementation fidelity is good (contact standards met, tools validated and unbiased, no safeguarding failures) and early indicators (plan quality, student satisfaction, referral times) are positive. **Gate 2 (month 24): scale decision.** Based on interim outcome evidence from the matched-comparison design and on cost per student against the model.

12.2 Measures that matter

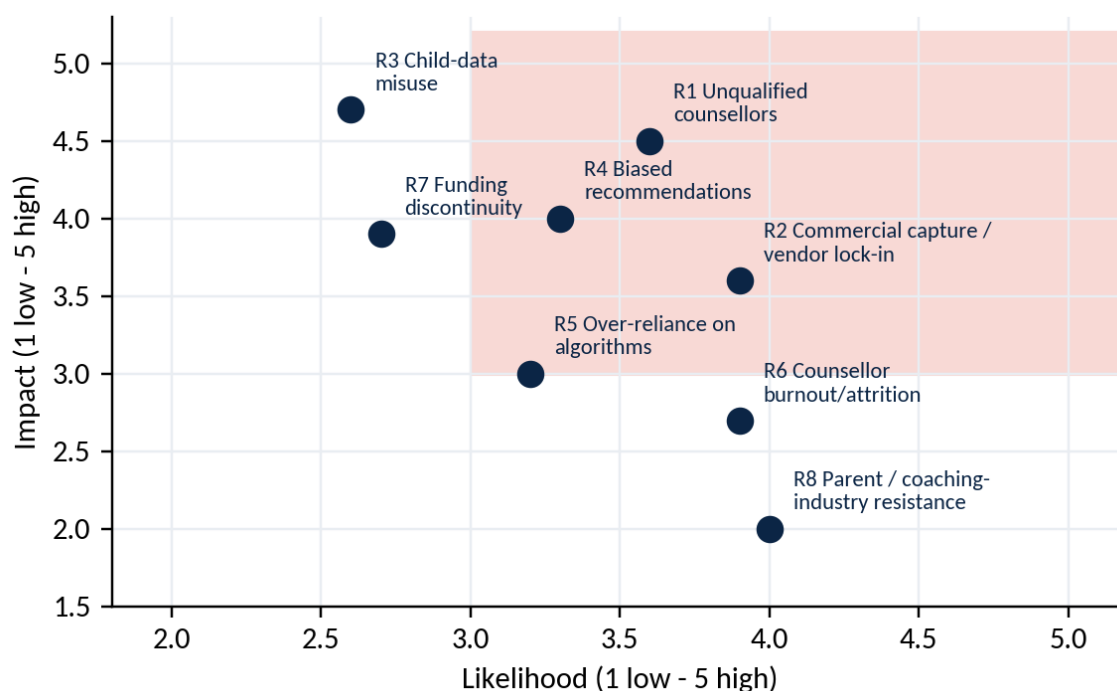
The list below is a proposed dashboard. Baselines are not yet available for most of these and should be established in the first six months. We do not state target values we cannot support; the pilot will calibrate them.

Level	Indicator	Why it matters
Input	Student-to-counsellor and student-to-coordinator ratios by district and school type	Tracks mandate compliance and equity of supply
Input	Share of counsellors registered, trained to standard and supervised	Quality of the workforce
Process	Share of Grade 9, 10 and 12 students receiving the decision-point sessions; parent attendance	Fidelity of delivery
Process	Share of tools with published validity and bias-audit evidence	Protects against unvalidated tools
Output	Share of students holding a documented, revisable plan with a primary and backup route	The immediate product of counselling
Outcome	Grade-11 stream switching; first-year undergraduate persistence and branch change	Quality of fit
Outcome	Time to first paid work and NEET share at 21 (matched cohorts)	School-to-work transition
Outcome	Validated wellbeing scales; help-seeking; referral timeliness	Safeguarding and wellbeing
Equity	All the above cut by gender, caste, income, disability and district	Ensures inclusion is not an afterthought

12.3 Risks and mitigations

EXHIBIT 18

Quality and child-safeguarding risks outrank funding risks



Source: Author's qualitative judgement of likelihood and impact; shaded area marks risks requiring explicit mitigation owners.

Risk	Mitigation
R1 Unqualified counsellors at scale	Three-tier standard; registry; supervised practice hours; inspection; do not scale beyond the capacity of supervisors
R2 Commercial capture / vendor lock-in	Open dataset and APIs; approved-provider list; conflict disclosure; no commission-driven steering
R3 Child-data misuse	Adopt DPDP standard from pilot day one; data minimisation; independent security review; no profiling or advertising
R4 Biased recommendations	Mandatory fairness audit pre- and post-deployment; explainable outputs; human interpretation; grievance route
R5 Over-reliance on algorithms	Present options not verdicts; counsellor must interpret; teach students to treat results as hypotheses
R6 Counsellor burnout and attrition	Caseload caps; supervision; career ladder from A to C; fair pay informed by registry data
R7 Funding discontinuity	Multi-year funding commitments; Gate-based release; ring-fenced Tier 3
R8 Parent and coaching-industry resistance	Parent sessions at decision points; publish outcome evidence; show backup routes are safe, not second best

The next 90 days

- Nominate a lead agency and a steering group that includes boards, a clinical-mental-health voice and a student representative.
- Commission the national competency framework and the registry design.
- Select three pilot states and 300 schools with a deliberate mix of urban, rural, government, private and first-generation intake.
- Pre-register the evaluation design and appoint an independent evaluator.
- Publish the assessment-validation and data-protection criteria that any provider must meet.
- Ask every institution to name its career lead and to protect timetabled career periods in Grades 8–12.

APPENDIX A

Practitioner reference sheets

Preserved from the original handbook, condensed, and annotated with the evidence caveats from Chapter 4.

A1 Holland codes (RIASEC): interest types

Type	Typical preferences	Example careers
Realistic (Doers)	Hands-on, outdoor, mechanical; prefers things to people; learns by doing	Engineer, veterinarian, technician
Investigative (Thinkers)	Analytical, curious, research and abstract problem-solving; works independently	Biologist, systems analyst, medical technologist
Artistic (Creators)	Imaginative, expressive, values aesthetics and flexibility; dislikes rigid structure	Musician, reporter, interior designer
Social (Helpers)	Warm, concerned for others; teaching, healing, counselling; teamwork	Teacher, counsellor, social worker
Enterprising (Persuaders)	Energetic, ambitious, persuasive; seeks leadership and economic goals	Sales lead, lawyer, business head
Conventional (Organisers)	Careful, orderly, numerate; data and records; defined procedures	Accountant, banker, company secretary

Use primary and secondary interests together: a student with a Social primary and Investigative secondary may suit psychology, counselling or health care. Note that Holland's types are broad tendencies, and the six-type structure has been tested more in Western than Indian samples.

A2 Big Five (OCEAN): personality traits

Trait	High scorers	Low scorers	Career relevance
Openness	Imaginative, curious, risk-taking	Practical, prefers routine	Creative, research, entrepreneurial work vs. structured roles
Conscientiousness	Organised, disciplined, goal-driven	Spontaneous, easily distracted	Consistently linked to job performance across roles
Extraversion	Outgoing, energised by people	Reserved, prefers independent work	Sales, leadership, public roles vs. analysis, craft
Agreeableness	Empathetic, cooperative	Competitive, sceptical	Care and service roles vs. negotiation, critical roles
Neuroticism	Reactive to stress	Calm under pressure	High-pressure roles may need coping skills; trainable, not disqualifying

No score is good or bad; a balanced profile and the fit to the work environment matter. Scores shift through adolescence and should be re-checked.

A3 Aptitude: seven areas

Area	What it measures	Example careers
Verbal	Understanding and reasoning with words	Journalist, lawyer, public speaker
Numerical	Speed and accuracy with numbers	Actuary, engineer, scientist
Spatial	Visualising 2D and 3D forms	Architect, designer, UI/UX
Perception	Completing a whole from partial information	Programmer, data scientist, animator
Accuracy	Rapid, accurate checking of detail	IT engineer, banker, analyst
Reasoning	Logical inference from abstract information	Researcher, mathematician
Mechanical	Understanding physical and mechanical principles	Mechanical or automotive engineer, pilot

Aptitude is a strong predictor of performance, but the original's statement that no amount of training can make someone considerably good at an activity they lack aptitude for is too strong; treat a low score as a challenge to plan for, not a prohibition.

A4 Multiple Intelligences (reflective vocabulary only)

Gardner's nine categories (linguistic, logical-mathematical, spatial, bodily-kinaesthetic, musical, interpersonal, intrapersonal, naturalistic, existential) are a helpful way to talk with students about different strengths, and the theory has influenced classroom practice. Most psychologists, however, do not regard them as separately measurable intelligences, and inventories built on them should not be used to predict career success or to rank options.

A5 Core counselling skills and approach

- **Fifteen basic skills:** attentiveness; active listening; verbal reinforcement; observation; open-ended questions; reflection; rephrasing; affirmation; summarising; empathy; concreteness; genuineness; well-timed silence; thoughtful follow-up questions; rapport building.
- **PLEASE technique:** Protect (a safe space), Listen, Enquire, Acknowledge, Support (praise and specific feedback), Exchange (share positive stories).
- **Do:** be present and non-judgemental; respect boundaries and confidentiality; give only solicited advice; use a mix of open and closed questions; speak simply; set realistic, actionable goals; equip students to take their own decisions.
- **Common barriers:** personal judgement; skipping rapport; low empathy; over-familiarity; inadequate skill; too much self-disclosure; burnout and low self-compassion; forgetting a student's details; over-identifying with students.

A6 First-session question bank and parent session

Student questions (open, strengths-based)	Parent session agenda (45 minutes)
1. Which activity, academic or not, do you enjoy most? 2. What is your proudest achievement so far? 3. What is your biggest failure and how did you recover? 4. Which life roles matter to you besides study and work? 5. What lifestyle do you imagine for yourself? 6. Do you enjoy travel? Where, and why? 7. What do you like most about your closest friend?	1. What the child is good at and enjoys, with evidence 2. How the assessments work and what they cannot tell us 3. Three to five options, including one the family may not have considered 4. Costs, entrance routes and timelines for each 5. The backup plan and why it is not a failure 6. How the family can help, and what to avoid 7. Agreed next steps and a review date

A7 A seven-step career plan (adapted from the original)

Self-assessment, research, experience (role play and exposure), goal-setting, skill-building, preparation (resume, network, interviews), then college and job search. Each step should leave a dated artefact in the student's career record.

APPENDIX B

What changed from the original, and why

A transparent record of claims retired, corrected or qualified.

Original statement or approach	Issue	Treatment in this edition
"93% of Indian students are aware of just seven careers; 80% are confused"	No primary source given; circulates in vendor material	Removed; replaced with verified indicators (Chapter 1)
Aptitudes stable by 13–14 and no training can compensate for a lack	Overstated; abilities, interests and personality continue to develop	Reframed as hypotheses; re-assessment built in (Chapter 4)
Aptitude is the most important factor in career selection	Over-weights one input; interests, values and circumstances also matter	Multi-factor fit with circumstances as a fourth input
Multiple Intelligences presented as an intelligence measure	Lacks empirical support as measurable constructs or predictors	Retained only as reflective vocabulary (Chapter 4, A4)
Rorschach and MMPI listed as tests counsellors can use	Clinical instruments requiring qualified clinicians; weak career validity	Excluded from career practice; graded in Exhibit 12
"45% of jobs can be automated" (McKinsey, 2015)	The finding concerns activities, not whole occupations (the original partly clarifies)	Replaced with 2025–26 evidence on entry-level effects
Shortage of about 15 lakh counsellors	Depends on the ratio assumed; no primary source	Recomputed at stated ratios with assumptions (Chapter 2)
No requirement for psychology background or licence	Out of date for CBSE schools since January 2026	Updated with CBSE and Supreme Court requirements
Digital and manual tests give same results (one practitioner)	Anecdote, not evidence	Procurement requires published equivalence evidence
Platform-specific claims on algorithm and library size	Not independently validated in the handbook	Replaced with provider-neutral procurement criteria
Case studies presented as outcomes	n = 32 self-report; no comparison group	Retained with caveats; evaluation design added
Mental-health tips without referral pathways	Did not reflect 2025 legal duties	Stepped-care model and escalation rules added (Chapter 7)

APPENDIX C

Model assumptions and sensitivity

Every modelled figure in this handbook can be reproduced from the inputs below.

Input	Value	Basis
Students, Classes 9–12	6.48 crore (3.72 + 2.76)	UDISE+ 2024-25
Fully-loaded cost per counsellor-year	₹5 lakh (range 4–6)	Planning assumption; no authoritative benchmark exists
Digital platform and content	₹150 per student per year	Planning assumption
Training and quality assurance	5% of payroll	Planning assumption
Teacher career-coordinator programme	₹100 per student per year (models B and C)	Planning assumption
Counsellor ratios	1:500, 1:1,000, 1:2,000 (and 1:250 for sizing)	CBSE; ASCA; illustrative
Scope	Career counsellors in Classes 9–12 only	Excludes socio-emotional counsellors, colleges, capital and set-up

Sensitivity of the tiered hybrid model (B), annual cost in ₹ crore

Variable	Low case	Base	High case
Counsellor cost ₹4 / 5 / 6 lakh	4,342	5,022	5,703
Platform cost ₹100 / 150 / 250 per student	4,698	5,022	5,670
Combined unfavourable (6 lakh and ₹250)	—	—	6,351

Base cases: A = ₹7,777 crore (₹1,200 per student); B = ₹5,022 crore (₹775); C = ₹3,321 crore (₹512). At roughly ₹85–90 to the US dollar, B is about US\$9 per student. Tier shares (about 10% Tier 3, 35–40% Tier 2) are indicative and not derived from data.

APPENDIX D

Sources and data notes

Where each figure comes from, and how much weight it can bear.

Topic	Source	Note
Youth and overall unemployment	MoSPI, PLFS Quarterly Bulletin Apr–Jun 2026; Monthly Bulletins 2026	Revamped series since Jan 2025 (Current Weekly Status); not comparable with earlier rounds. Accessed via secondary summaries
Global jobs and skills	World Economic Forum, Future of Jobs Report 2025	Employer survey; global, not India-specific
AI and entry-level hiring	ICRIER, <i>AI and Jobs: This Time Is No Different</i> (Feb 2026); Nomura via Business Today (Aug 2026); World Bank WDR 2026 as reported	IT-sector focus; analyst and press summaries
Employability	India Skills Report 2026 (Wheebox/ETS)	Industry-sponsored test; indicative. Not an employment rate
School pipeline	UDISE+ 2024-25, Ministry of Education	Adopts NEP stage definitions; secondary figures vary by definition across secondary summaries
Higher education	AISHE 2022-23 and 2023-24 (released July 2026)	Self-reported by institutions
Competitive-exam funnel	NTA NEET-UG 2026; MBBS seat matrix 2026-27 as reported	Registrations include repeaters; a re-examination was also held in 2026
Student suicides	NCRB, ADSI 2014, 2023, 2024	2024 and 2014 figures via press summaries; 2019 and 2022 derived from reported growth; NCRB records a single stated cause
Adolescent mental health	NIMHANS, NMHS 2015–16 (12 states); WHO (2021) as cited in the original; Lok Sabha replies (Dec 2025)	Survey is a decade old; NMHS 2.0 pending
Legal and policy	Supreme Court, <i>Sukdeb Saha v. State of AP</i> , 2025 INSC 893; CBSE circular 19 Jan 2026; DPDP Act 2023 and Rules 2025	Reported via legal and news summaries; read primary texts before relying on specific clauses
Guidance evidence	OECD Career Readiness working papers (Mann, Denis and Percy 2020; Covacevich et al. 2021)	Associational evidence
Original handbook	ProTeen, <i>Career Counselling in the 21st Century</i> (2022)	Source of framework, case studies and practitioner content; several statistics unsourced

Appendix E: Glossary

Term	Meaning
CACG	Computer-assisted career guidance: digital systems linking assessments to occupational information
GER	Gross Enrolment Ratio: enrolment as a share of the relevant age group
NEET (labour)	Not in Employment, Education or Training; distinct from the NEET entrance exam
PLFS	Periodic Labour Force Survey, MoSPI
RIASEC	Holland's six interest types
Tele-MANAS	National tele-mental-health service, toll-free 14416
UDISE+	Unified District Information System for Education Plus
DPDP	Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 and Rules 2025